relations with its northern neighbour, then the Tamilian cause shaped India's foreign relations with its neighbour in the south.

Sri Lanka

Tamil Nadu in south India is home to the majority of the Tamil-speaking population. But there is another important Tamil world in the little island nation facing Tamil Nadu across the Palk Straits. It, in fact, houses more than one variant of Tamil. Since 1911, the Census of Sri Lanka, then Ceylon, began to classify the Tamilians as either Sri Lankan or Indian to distinguish between two different migrations. The Sri Lankan Tamilians are the descendants of early settlers from south India who originally arrived for the purpose of conquest, and are found in the northern and eastern parts of Sri Lanka.[59] The Indian Tamilians refer to the plantation labour migrants who began arriving since the 19th century and their descendants. They are also called the Hill Country Tamils and live mainly in the central highlands. In 1911, the Tamilians comprised a quarter of the population, equally split between the Indian and Sri Lankan Tamilians. This figure only marginally declined until the 1950s. By then, in absolute terms, they were about a million each. Over the next fifty years, the absolute magnitudes and population shares dipped substantially due to violence and mass exodus.

The Sinhalese (Buddhist) were the dominant ethnic group comprising two-thirds of the island's population in the middle of the 20th century. After gaining independence from British rule in 1948, they began to assert their dominance, making Sinhala the official language in 1956 and enforcing policies in education, employment and investment that led to widespread cries of discrimination from the Tamilians. The Indian Tamilians or estate labour were the first casualties as most of them were considered to be 'Indian nationals' according to the newly drawn Sri Lankan citizenship laws. But at the same time they were seen as 'stateless' in India due to their long stay in Sri Lanka.[60] The Indo-Ceylon pact of 1964, or the Sirima-Shastri Pact, attempted to resolve this issue by agreeing on a formula of repatriation and non-repatriation. Some 3,00,000 Tamilians would receive